Charity Partner Quick Screen

The short form of the eleven-criterion review — a fast pass to decide whether a charitable organization clears the bar, before or during a fundraising engagement. Use the full Standards Review when a criterion needs a closer look.

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This is a fillable form. Tap or click any box or field to complete it on a phone, tablet or computer. To keep your answers, save the file from your PDF app: on iPhone/iPad use the share icon, then “Save to Files” (or open it in Books); on Android use “Save a copy” in Acrobat or a PDF editor; in a desktop browser or Acrobat use “Save as” / download. Google Drive’s built-in preview is read-only — open the file in a PDF editor first.

For each criterion, tick what you can confirm, note anything open, and give it a rating. A single Fails blocks a new engagement or triggers corrective action on a current one. Rate N/A only with a reason.

Meets — evidence present and adequate · Minor gaps — mostly there, small fixes · Material concern — real weakness, needs a plan and a re-check · Fails — absent or deficient, a blocker · N/A — not applicable (say why)

ORGANIZATION UNDER REVIEW

LEGAL NAME / DBA

EIN

WEBSITE

PURPOSE OF REVIEW

- ○ Prospective — considering an engagement
- ○ Current — periodic review

REVIEWER

DATE

PART A — LEGAL & REGULATORY STANDING

1 Tax-exempt status & finances

Confirms the organization is a recognised public charity in good standing and that its money holds up to inspection.

- ☐ Current IRS 501(c)(3) determination letter; listed active in IRS Tax Exempt Organization Search (not auto-revoked)
- ☐ Legal name and EIN match across the letter, the Forms 990, the website and bank details
- ☐ Last three Forms 990 filed on time; the full form where revenue requires it
- ☐ Program spending is a clear majority of expense; fundraising and admin are reasonable and stable year to year
- ☐ Independent board majority; conflict-of-interest and whistleblower policies in place; board reviews the 990

WATCH FOR
Can’t produce the determination letter; auto-revoked or lapsed; multi-year deficits or negative net assets; fundraising cost a large or rising share of contributions; payments to companies tied to board or staff.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

2 Solicitation registration, fundraiser bond & permits

Confirms the organization — and the fundraising firm acting for it — is registered, bonded and permitted everywhere the work will happen. State and local rules vary; confirm with counsel.

- ☐ Charitable-solicitation registration active in every state where it solicits
- ☐ Professional fundraiser / solicitor registered and bonded where required (bond current, meets the state minimum)
- ☐ Written charity–firm contract with the state-mandated disclosures, filed where required
- ☐ Local canvassing / solicitation permits for the specific areas to be worked
- ☐ No open or recent enforcement action from any state attorney general or charity regulator

WATCH FOR
"We don't need to register" with no written basis; expired registrations or unfiled state reports; no bond where one is required; any regulator action or assurance of voluntary compliance over solicitation.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

PART B — PUBLIC IDENTITY & COMMUNICATIONS

3 Website

Confirms the organization is real, current and transparent to a donor who checks after a doorstep conversation.

- ☐ Organization-owned domain, loads over HTTPS, design consistent with its other materials
- ☐ Named leadership and board with bios; a real address and a working phone and email
- ☐ Financials posted (annual report, audited statements or the 990) and a secure donate path
- ☐ Updated within roughly the last quarter

WATCH FOR
No named leadership or address; no financials anywhere; donate button to a personal payment handle; nothing updated in a year; impact numbers that don't match the 990.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

4 Social media

Confirms the organization is active and handles public questions and criticism professionally.

- ☐ Official accounts linked from the website, consistent name and branding
- ☐ Posts at least monthly with real program content, not only donation asks
- ☐ Engagement looks organic; complaints and questions answered in public, professionally

WATCH FOR
Dormant or abandoned accounts; engagement wildly out of line with follower count; unanswered or hostile replies; content that contradicts the organization's own claims.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

5 Newsletters & donor communications

Confirms the organization reports back to donors rather than only asking.

- [ ] A regular newsletter (email and/or print), several recent issues, reporting on program impact
- [ ] Gift acknowledgements are prompt and carry the IRS-required details (organization name, the amount or a description of what was given, and whether goods or services were given in return)
- [ ] A clear, honoured unsubscribe / contact-preference process

WATCH FOR
No donor communication in the last year; every message an emergency appeal with no reporting on prior gifts; acknowledgements missing required elements or not sent.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

6 Letterhead & official stationery

Confirms the engagement is properly documented — field reps carry an authorization letter donors and property owners ask to see.

- [ ] Professional letterhead with the legal name, address, phone, EIN and a 501(c)(3) line
- [ ] A current, signed, dated authorization letter naming the fundraising firm, the territory and the date range
- [ ] A gift-receipt template with the IRS-required substantiation language
- [ ] Branding consistent across letterhead, website and social accounts

WATCH FOR
No letterhead or an informal template; authorization letter undated, unsigned or generic about scope; a different legal name or address than the determination letter.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

7 Public relations & reputation

Confirms independent credibility — and surfaces solicitation complaints or regulator actions before they become the firm's problem.

- [ ] Some verifiable earned media or third-party recognition, not only paid placements
- [ ] Watchdog profiles claimed and acceptable (Charity Navigator, Candid Seal, BBB Wise Giving, CharityWatch)
- [ ] Independent search shows no material litigation, regulator actions, or pattern of donor complaints
- [ ] A named person owns fundraising-related inquiries and complaints

WATCH FOR
No third-party footprint; low or unclaimed watchdog profiles; lawsuits or AG inquiries alleging misuse of funds or deceptive solicitation; recurring complaints about aggressive or misleading fundraising.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

PART C — PROGRAMS & EVIDENCE

8 Program content & documented outcomes

Confirms every claim a rep will make on the doorstep traces to a real program and a countable source.

- ☐ Written description of each program: who is served, what's delivered, where, and how many
- ☐ Current-year output numbers, with a note on how each one is counted
- ☐ Outcome measures, not just outputs — what changed for the people served
- ☐ Numbers are consistent across program docs, the website, social posts and the 990
- ☐ Programs match the exempt purpose in the determination letter

WATCH FOR
Vague mission, no specific programs, no numbers; large round claims with no denominator or source; figures that conflict between documents; the "program" is mostly awareness or marketing.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

9 Testimonials & third-party validation

Confirms independent voices — beneficiaries, partner institutions, funders — corroborate the program story.

- ☐ Specific, attributable testimonials (not anonymous one-liners), with consent on file for anyone featured
- ☐ A few named institutional partners or funders who can be contacted for a reference
- ☐ Third-party validation is recent (last year or two)

WATCH FOR
Only anonymous, generic quotes; stock imagery presented as beneficiaries; no partners or funders; nothing that can be corroborated; identifiable vulnerable people featured with no evidence of consent.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

PART D — ORGANIZATIONAL CLARITY

10 Structure, facts & figures

Confirms the organization can state plainly what it is, who runs it and how big — and that it matches the filings.

- ☐ An org chart and a current board roster (names, outside affiliations, terms)

- [ ] Bylaws and key governance policies; the board meets and keeps minutes
- [ ] A facts sheet: legal name, EIN, year founded, staff and volunteer count, budget, service area, number served
- [ ] Independent board majority; not family-controlled; chair, treasurer and executive director are different people
- [ ] For a current partner: past campaign results, scoped by period and campaign, pulled from a named system

WATCH FOR
No org chart or current board list; a tiny or family board; no bylaws or minutes; facts that shift between conversations or don't match the filings.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

PART E — FUNDRAISING OVERSIGHT

11 Representative management & field conduct

Confirms the relationship is documented, reps have approved messaging and identification, and complaints have somewhere to go.

- [ ] A signed, current charity–firm agreement: scope, territory, supervision, required disclosures, termination, insurance, data ownership
- [ ] A written code of conduct and an approved script / FAQ; disclosure practice matches the rules for every state worked
- [ ] Rep identification (badges) and a public way for a donor to verify a rep is authorized
- [ ] Donor-data handling: secure transmission, retention, do-not-contact / suppression, and a card-data policy
- [ ] A documented complaint process with named owners and response times — and evidence it has been used
- [ ] The organization actively monitors field conduct rather than delegating it entirely to the firm

WATCH FOR
Handshake deal or expired contract; scripts that promise outcomes or hide paid-solicitor status; no way to verify a rep; complaints go nowhere; the organization "doesn't get involved" in how its name is used in the field.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

OUTCOME

IF PROSPECTIVE

- ○ Proceed
- ○ Proceed with conditions
- ○ Hold pending fixes / remediation
- ○ Decline

IF CURRENT PARTNER

- ○ Continue
- ○ Continue with corrective-action plan
- ○ Suspend pending remediation
- ○ Begin exit

CONDITIONS / NOTES

REVIEWED BY / DATE

APPROVED BY / DATE

NEXT REVIEW	FILE REFERENCE

Internal screening tool, not legal advice. Charitable-solicitation registration, fundraiser bonding, disclosure language and permit rules are specific to each state and locality and change over time — confirm current requirements with qualified counsel, and the organization's own financial position with its accountant.